

Is Canada's Focus on Eliminating U.S. Automotive Tariffs Dragging Us Back Into The 20th Century?

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Introduction

In mid-2025, after an executive order signed by the Trump Administration on February 10th,¹ 11th² and March 26th, the United States enacted 25% tariffs on key Canadian manufacturing industries such as steel, aluminium, and automotives.³ Unsatisfied, the Trump administration recently escalated threats to further raise tariffs on Canadian goods to 50% to extract further trade concessions from Canada.⁴

On Tuesday late last week, hours before they were to come into effect, the US President Donald Trump announced that he would be delaying the increase to 50% tariffs for three days because of possible progress on a new trade deal with Canada.

This three-day break was better read as a pause than as progress. As aptly noted, "There is [still] no guarantee Canada can dodge tariffs long-term",⁵ and fittingly, this week, after the US administration changed its mind and added a series of last minute demands—including that Canada relinquish its ability to sign trade independently with other nations—negotiations again fell apart.⁶

¹ Donald J. Trump, "Adjusting Imports of Steel into the United States," White House, February 10, 2025, <https://www.whitehouse.gov/presidential-actions/2025/02/adjusting-imports-of-steel-into-the-united-states/>.

² Donald J. Trump, "Adjusting Imports of Aluminum into the United States," White House, February 11, 2025, <https://www.whitehouse.gov/presidential-actions/2025/02/adjusting-imports-of-aluminum-into-the-united-states/>.

³ Prime Minister of Canada, "Canada Announces New Countermeasures in Response to Tariffs from the United States of America," news release, April 3, 2025.

⁴ Rhianna Schmunk and John Paul Tasker, "Trump Pauses 50 per Cent Tariffs on Canadian Goods for 3 Days," *CBC News*, August 18, 2026, <https://www.cbc.ca/news/politics/new-trump-tariffs-deadline-9.7311125>.

⁵ Schmunk and Tasker, "Trump Pauses 50 per Cent Tariffs."

⁶ Ashley Burke, "What We Know about How the Canada-U.S. Trade Talks Fell Apart," *CBC News*, August 24, 2026. <https://www.cbc.ca/news/politics/carney-trump-trade-talks-broke-down-9.7318903>.

The stakes are high. Around \$2.5 billion USD of goods and services cross the US-Canada border each day, and the tariffs on Canadian automobiles are expected to affect “the more than 500,000 Canadians” the industry supports.⁷

Whether the tariffs are eventually implemented, the uncertainty caused from the cycle of repeated threats, stand-downs, then escalations, have already destabilized the economy by making it harder for businesses to know if they should invest in Canada—since the decision is largely contingent on whether Canada will continue to remain tightly integrated with US economy (if not, they should invest directly in the US instead).⁸

This note examines whether the current geopolitical environment and tensions over trade are creating a misguided focus on eliminating US automotive tariffs—to preserve jobs in an industry with an unstable fate—at the expense of prioritizing national attention towards more secure, forward-looking technologies and sectors.

Markets Produce Vested Interests Over Time

A common critique from skeptics of free market capitalism is that markets produce vested interests in favor of Capital. As domestic industries develop, rational self-interest means successful businesses become invested in the continued existence of those sectors. Unfortunately, the nature of markets is to eventually produce structures that automatically enforce the interests of industry against policy changes and state regulation.⁹

Yet this understates the mechanism. In reality, over time, markets create vested interests for both Capital (e.g. lobbyists, investors) and Labor (e.g. union groups, workers) to maintain the status quo. Presently, both are fighting to make the case to keep Canada’s struggling automotive industry alive.

Is This Realistic?

Before looking at the policy arguments for why Canada should pivot, we should examine whether the political case for defending the automotive industry is even realistic. Let us look at the facts.

⁷ Prime Minister of Canada, “Canada Announces New Countermeasures.”

⁸ Jeff Lagerquist and Abby Hughes, “‘Owners Are Afraid’: New Tariffs Could Cut Sales in Half for Some Canadian Businesses,” *CBC News*, August 18, 2026, <https://www.cbc.ca/news/business/tariff-deadline-small-businesses-brace-9.7310021>.

⁹ Charles E. Lindblom, “The Market as Prison,” *Journal of Politics* 44, no. 2 (May 1982): 324–36, <https://doi.org/10.2307/2130588>.

Per CBC News, “On autos, the latest U.S. offer would lower the tariffs on Canadian-made vehicles to a headline rate of 15 per cent, down from the current 25 per cent.”¹⁰ In return, the US is demanding that Canada make changes to supply management of the dairy industry to increase American imports and remove retaliatory tariffs on American automotives.

If a trade where you agree to go from 25% to 0%,¹¹ so that the other party goes down from 25% to 15% sounds unreasonable to you, you’ve already identified the first reason this is unrealistic. Here’s the second: by the own head of Automotive Parts Manufacturers’ Association (APMA)’s admission, “any negotiated tariff rate must be below the profit margin” of 6% for an agreement to make sense.¹²

This implies that even if after a subsequent round of negotiations, the US further halved their tariff rate, realistically, this would still not be enough for the automotive sector in Canada to survive.

The question then is how much further should we be willing to make concessions just to protect an automotive sector, which, even as a purely political question, could only survive if we identified enough ‘acceptable sacrifices’ to improve the current arrangement more than twofold.

The Future of Canada’s Automotive Sector and the Price of Our Trade Concessions

Moving away from the political question, it further helps to ask from a policy perspective what the costs and implications are of our focus on preserving the automotive sector. First, the United States seems abundantly willing to take the automotive sector hostage in negotiations with Canada.

This should be a warning that even success here may mean further integration with an entity that simply becomes a precursor to providing an adversary with more leverage.

Second, the full question is not ‘if we should save the automotive industry’ but if we should save an industry that if it survives, would mean we might have to save it again, by increasingly making more and more concessions in other key industries, especially when the cost of ‘winning’ plausibly involves:

1. Making additional sacrifices in sectors where we are already self-sufficient (e.g. supply management in dairy) and hence where jobs are safe from political turmoil.

¹⁰ Schmunk and Tasker, “Trump Pauses 50 per Cent Tariffs.”

¹¹ Retaliatory tariffs are currently matched at 25%.

¹² CTVNews.ca Staff, “PM Carney Asks Provinces to Return U.S. Booze to Shelves, Nova Scotia Premier Says. Live Trade Updates Here,” *CTV News*, updated August 19, 2026

2. Saving sectors where market dynamics (e.g. increasing automation of factory work, decreasing demand for gas-powered vehicles due to climate change) are likely to reduce the economic benefits to Canadian workers and businesses anyway.
3. Dividing our effort and attention from industries in which we already have a head start, or are likely to catch up, where learning by doing means the sooner we start, the bigger the industry will be, the more people it can employ, and the more we stand to accelerate gains from expertise in practical implementation.

Efficient Institutions Do Not Guarantee Globally Optimal Solutions

Third, one might argue that the vested interests produced by free markets are not a ‘bug’ but a feature of a system that selects “for the emergence of efficient organizations [...] by driving less-efficient organizations out of business.”¹³ In a proximate sense, this is true. For the most part, institutions are ‘governance structures’ which develop to reduce transaction costs.¹⁴

But on a mathematical level, an efficient solution can still represent a local optimum—something which is best in an immediate context, but sub-optimal when one looks at the bigger picture. So let us look at the bigger picture.

Catching Up By Giving Up: China’s Pivot to Electric Vehicles

In 2001, during the 10th Five-Year Plan, the *863 Program* (China’s high-tech development plan) explicitly identified new energy vehicles (NEVs) as a potential future industry where China could gain a technological lead and become a first-mover.¹⁵

A key figure in this was Wan Gang, an engineer who had worked for Audi in Germany for about a decade, and advised the Chinese government to begin taking steps to become a leader in NEVs as a strategy for becoming a global player in vehicle manufacturing.¹⁶

The idea was to ‘leapfrog’ the West by conceding to its dominance in legacy automotive technology and internal combustion engines. Instead of competing where it was already behind,

¹³ Avner Greif and Christopher Kingston, “Institutions: Rules or Equilibria?,” in *Political Economy of Institutions, Democracy and Voting*, ed. Norman Schofield and Gonzalo Caballero (Springer, 2011), at 20.

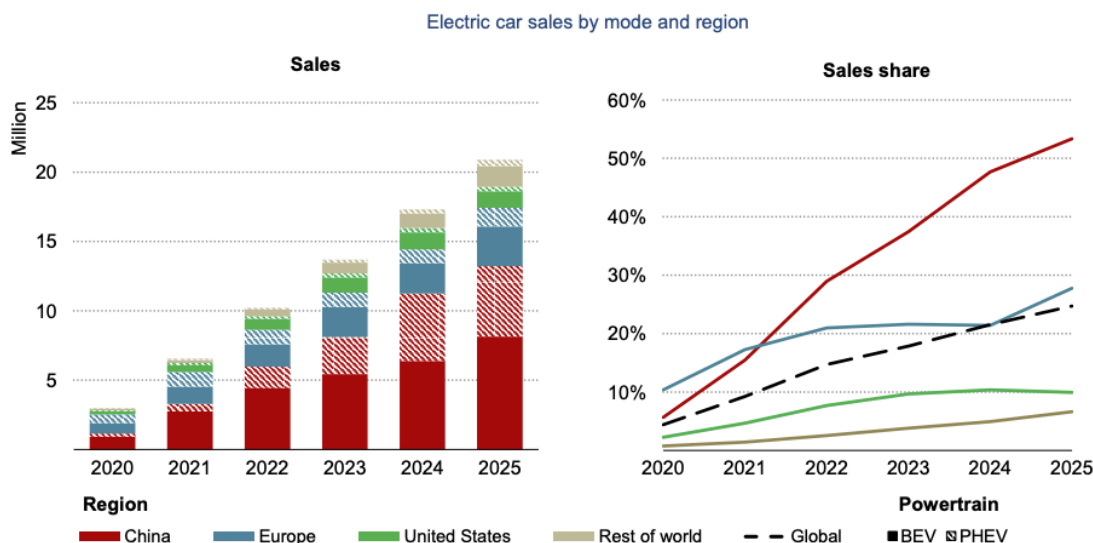
¹⁴ Oliver E. Williamson, “Transaction-Cost Economics: The Governance of Contractual Relations,” *The Journal of Law and Economics* 22, no. 2 (1979): 233-261, at 245-246.

¹⁵ Peng Yu et al., “The Evolution of China’s New Energy Vehicle Industry from the Perspective of a Technology–Market–Policy Framework,” *Sustainability* 11, no. 6 (2019): 1711.

¹⁶ Echo Huang, “The Man Who Ushered in China’s Battery Vehicle Boom Wants to Do the Same for Fuel Cells,” *Quartz*, originally published April 17, 2019, updated July 21, 2022.

China pivoted to identifying and investing in technologies that were likely to represent the industries of the future. From a naive first observation, this appears to have worked.¹⁷

Global electric car sales reached 25% of global car sales, exceeding 20 million in 2025



IEA. CC BY 4.0.

The instructive lesson here is not necessarily that the tight integration of Canada's legacy automotive industry and dependency on the US should prompt a pivot towards becoming an electric vehicle manufacturer (although that may well be the eventual conclusion we reach).

It is that Canada should now identify key sectors where we are likely to either already hold a lead, or gain one. Luckily, on this matter, some of the groundwork has already been laid.

Things We Could Focus On Instead

The Canadian scientific and research community has already positioned us for a possible lead in a number of emerging technologies. While not quite a leader in global markets yet—given that many of these technologies have not attained commercial viability—Canada's highly-educated population¹⁸ provides a unique pool of talent to draw from, if we decide to pivot and fully commit to building up these future industries.

¹⁷ International Energy Agency, *Global Critical Minerals Outlook 2026*, revised July 2026 (IEA, 2026), at 63. <https://www.iea.org/reports/global-critical-minerals-outlook-2026>.

¹⁸ By a 2025 report from Statistics Canada, just under two-thirds of Canadians (64%) between ages 25-64 hold a college or university degree. See: <https://www150.statcan.gc.ca/n1/daily-quotidien/260325/dq260325c-eng.htm>

Fusion Power

In the words of the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA), “fusion has entered a decisive new phase”. While “once confined to experimental research”, fusion is likely close to reaching market viability in the near-future. A common joke is that nuclear fusion is always perpetually 10-15 years away¹⁹ - yet recent policy and financial developments suggest that markets are beginning to take this seriously.

Global private investment into nuclear fusion R&D passed \$10 billion USD in 2025. Although there are currently no commercially operating fusion power plants, the World Fusion Energy Group has already begun developing frameworks to harmonize standards across jurisdictions before it enters the market.^{20 21}

In Canada, *General Fusion*, founded in 2002 by a physicist from the University of British Columbia, has made significant progress on a unique approach (“magnetized target fusion”) that aims to use compressed plasma without superconductors or expensive, high-powered lasers, to avoid the cost barriers currently frustrating financial viability.²²

On the policy side, The Centre for Fusion Energy,²³ founded in 2025 by the Government of Canada, the Province of Ontario, Canadian Nuclear Laboratories and a number of other organizations, are laying the groundwork for a future integrated Canadian fusion ecosystem.

Quantum Computing

Canada is one of the leaders in both technical research and early commercial development for quantum computing. Xanadu (Toronto)’s state of the art (‘SOTA’) quantum computer recently accomplished a task that would have required over 9000 years to complete on a “conventional supercomputer” in 36 microseconds.^{24 25}

¹⁹ Aryn Baker, “Nuclear Fusion Finally Finds Its Place in the Sun,” *Time*, November 24, 2021, 9:38 a.m. ET, <https://time.com/6123622/nuclear-fusion-viability/>.

²⁰ Emma Midgley, “Fusion Energy in 2025: Six Global Trends to Watch,” International Atomic Energy Agency, October 28, 2025.

²¹ International Atomic Energy Agency, *IAEA World Fusion Outlook 2025*, 3rd ed., IAEA/PAT/012 (International Atomic Energy Agency, October 2025), 1–89, at 18.

²² International Atomic Energy Agency, *World Fusion Outlook 2025*, at 18.

²³ Canadian Nuclear Laboratories, “Federal Government Continues Investment in Fusion Sector to Establish Centre for Fusion Energy,” news release, November 28, 2025. <https://www.cnl.ca/federal-government-continues-investment-in-fusion-sector-to-establish-centre-for-fusion-energy/>.

²⁴ Muhammad AbuGhanem and Hichem Eleuch, “NISQ Computers: A Path to Quantum Supremacy,” *IEEE Access* 12 (2024): 102941–61, at 8.

²⁵ Lars S. Madsen et al., “Quantum Computational Advantage with a Programmable Photonic Processor,” *Nature* 606, no. 7912 (2022): 75–81.

Nord Quantique (Quebec)—spun out of the University of Sherbrooke’s *Institut quantique* and founded only in 2020—was recently valued at \$1.4 billion USD after completing its latest funding round in mid-2026.²⁶

The University of Waterloo’s *Institute for Quantum Computing* has also been a major player in the study and advancement of quantum computing in Canada, and together with a number of other Canadian institutions—under Canada’s “National Quantum Strategy”—are now helping develop post-quantum cryptography standards before the technology fully arrives.²⁷

New Paradigms in AI

Few technologies have gained prominence as quickly as modern (deep neural network-based) artificial intelligence (‘AI’). One of the most notable features of this explosive industry is the almost complete global dominance by just two countries, China and the United States.²⁸ It should seem overly optimistic to think Canada might compete here.

But this is the lesson of the internal combustion engine. Current AI may be where we lag far behind. However, crucial work by Chris Eliasmith and others—also out of the University of Waterloo—on spiking neural networks (SNNs), a potential new paradigm in AI inspired by a closer biological approach, has shown promise.²⁹

Regular artificial neural networks (ANNs) used in modern machine learning are slow but powerful, and precise but energy-intensive, partly due to the nature of the (computationally) expensive ‘multiply-accumulate’ operations involved.³⁰

Spiking neural networks use a different technique (temporal processing) to reduce the amount of information that needs to be communicated between nodes in a network and “replace the multipliers in the MAC arrays with adders”, providing immense gains in energy efficiency.³¹

²⁶ Ramesh Manikundu, “Nord Quantique Explained: \$1.4B Quantum Unicorn, Bosonic Qubits, Error-Correction Breakthroughs & 2030 Roadmap,” *QuantumWay*, August 16, 2026, <https://www.quantumway.org/post/nord-quantique-explained-1-4b-quantum-unicorn-bosonic-qubits-error-correction-breakthroughs-20>.

²⁷ Innovation, Science and Economic Development Canada, *Canada’s National Quantum Strategy*, Catalogue no. Iu4-414/2022E-PDF (Ottawa: Government of Canada, 2022).

²⁸ Luz Ding et al., “US Lead in the AI Race With China Is Rapidly Narrowing,” *Bloomberg*, August 19, 2026, <https://www.bloomberg.com/graphics/2026-us-china-ai-race/>.

²⁹ Eric Hunsberger and Chris Eliasmith, “Training Spiking Deep Networks for Neuromorphic Hardware,” arXiv preprint arXiv:1611.05141v1 (November 16, 2016): 1–10

³⁰ Aaron R. Voelker, Daniel Rasmussen, and Chris Eliasmith, “A Spike in Performance: Training Hybrid-Spiking Neural Networks with Quantized Activation Functions,” arXiv preprint arXiv:2002.03553v2 (March 1, 2021), at 8.

³¹ Voelker et al., “Spike in Performance,” at 8.

Prima facie, SNNs, may well present a future path to leapfrogging the US and China in AI by allowing to reap the gains of the technology without the major environmental/social costs and regulatory hurdles of building massive datacenters.

Reskilling Blue-Collar Workers into Domestically In-Demand Industries

Under the Carney administration, Canada has already identified the lack of housing supply as a key policy issue. Crucially, the government has also identified the lack of skilled tradesmen and construction workers as a key hurdle in alleviating the bottleneck of housing.³²

Of course, just because automotive jobs and construction work are both physical-labor, blue-collar industries does not mean everything transfers one to one. Nor that there will be no friction from structural unemployment (a mismatch between the skills workers' have and the skills in-demand).³³

But if this note's argument is that we should abandon the hostage-taken automotive sector in favor of a pivot to fully investing and committing to becoming a future leader in current, emerging technologies—the caveat is that a good industrial policy *cannot* optimistically chart a path for the future while abandoning our workers in past, key industries.

Conclusion

A stable policy solution must appeal to the interests and institutions of both Capital and Labor.

On the automotive sector: to businesses, we must make the case that an industry saved at the expense of other Canadian workers and industries through an agreement with a country that has already shown brazen willingness to treat trade as leverage, and see sovereigns as vassals, is not something even they would want.

Businesses require stability and predictability to thrive, and an industry so tightly integrated with a country whose political dictates change on a whim, is not a profitable future - let alone a profit-maximizing one.

To workers, we must demonstrate compassion and foresight in making the case that a painful pivot today is the price of a prosperous future tomorrow. But compassion must be more than lip service. The government should begin coordinating now with key actors in the housing and construction sectors to identify precisely what work is needed, and what skills are missing.

³² Nathaniel Barr et al., "Skilled-Trades Training Needs a Rethink," *Policy Options*, August 19, 2026.

³³ Guy Standing, "The Notion of Structural Unemployment," *International Labour Review* 122, no. 2 (March–April 1983): 137–53.

Moreover, it must learn from past re-training programs and focus on the gaps in “engagement, uptake, and completion rates” rather than just training opportunities alone.³⁴

A change in industrial policy as ambitious as this requires effort and time. Fortunately, Canada has already paid the costs of both. From the National Quantum Strategy,³⁵ to the Nuclear Energy Strategy,³⁶ to Canada’s National Artificial Intelligence Strategy,³⁷ the Canadian government has already shown an ambitious, strategic commitment to being part of the global forces that will help invent the future.

What we need now is to step out of the past, and commit ourselves to collecting the returns on our investments into the future.

³⁴ Barr et al., “Skilled-Trades Training.”

³⁵ Innovation, Science and Economic Development Canada, *National Quantum Strategy*.

³⁶ Natural Resources Canada, *Nuclear Energy Strategy for Canada*, Catalogue no. M134-81/2026E-PDF (June 22, 2026).

³⁷ Innovation, Science and Economic Development Canada, *Canada’s National Artificial Intelligence Strategy: AI for All*, Catalogue no. lu4-458/2026E-PDF (Innovation, Science and Economic Development Canada, 2026).

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